outside his Tughlaq Lane residence with cakes and garlands. Only the birthday boy was never there—he was beating the summer heat abroad with undoubtedly much more fun folk than Congress netas!

Rahul, it appeared, had very few close friends in politics. There were a few MPs who the media scornfully referred to as the *babalog* MPs (the word 'babalog' was first used for Rajiv Gandhi's coterie, his Doon School–Cambridge buddies like Arun Singh, Suman Dubey, Vivek Bharat Ram and Romi Chopra) whom he would occasionally hang out with. The likes of Jyotiraditya Scindia, Milind Deora and Jitin Prasada were in the same age group as Rahul Gandhi. Like him, they, too, came from illustrious political families, spoke fine English, were educated abroad, and had perhaps similar cultural tastes and hobbies. Jyotiraditya's father Madhavrao had been a close family friend and a Cabinet minister in Rajiv Gandhi's government. Deora plays a rather swinging rock guitar and Rahul Gandhi has been spotted at Deora's gigs. His father Murli was a Rajiv loyalist who had stood by the Gandhi family. Prasada's father had fought for the Congress presidency against Sonia Gandhi in 1999 and lost. The shared past perhaps made it easier for this Congress Generation Next to bond with one another.

One of the few exceptions to this 'people like us' syndrome encircling Rahul was Meenakshi Natarajan, a rare young Congress leader to rise in the party hierarchy without a famous surname. Natarajan who won the Lok Sabha elections in 2009 from Mandsaur was proof that Rahul's experiment to break the Congress's traditional structures could work only if it was pushed through with firmness at every level. Sadly, that did not happen.

Perhaps, Rahul Gandhi needed that comfort factor in being surrounded in his private life by people with similar values and upbringing. He was happiest in the company of those with whom he could be himself, with whom he could go gymming, cycling and biking (he has a fascination, I am told, for Harley-Davidson bikes). After witnessing terrible tragedy within the family at an early age, he had lived a sheltered life and had spent an extended period of his early adulthood out of the country. He had every right to his privacy, but forgot a cardinal principle of contemporary politics —a full-time politician has almost no private life. Genuine mass leaders